

Zootopia 2 movie review

I loved Zootopia back in 2016, and I still love it now. It's memorable for its clever humor, likable characters, and examination of complex societal problems. While the movie features a villain, most of the city's problems stem from deep-seated, ancient conflicts among the animal species dwelling in it. The music and visuals were obvious highlights as well, but Zootopia stood out for being a little more high-minded than the typical Disney fare. I had little to no hope that Zootopia 2 would reach any of the first film's high points, but does it? Let's find out.

Zootopia 2 finds Nick and Judy riding the high of saving and reuniting the city at the end of Zootopia. However, this emboldens them, especially Judy, to be reckless and take charge in a case where they're instructed to observe. This incident inadvertently gets the dynamic duo sent to cop therapy, but more importantly, Judy discovers that there's a snake in Zootopia. Unsurprisingly, Nick and Judy have very different plans going forward. Judy wants to find and apprehend the snake, but Nick would rather follow Chief Bogo's orders and lie low. A mysterious ally steps in to help Judy, while Nick takes another path. Can the two heroes reunite to save the city once more? Is water wet?

Most of my problems with Zootopia 2 stem from my having already seen Zootopia. Without getting into spoilers, the story's broad strokes are very similar to the first movie. This film's overall conflict and message are remarkably similar to the first Zootopia as well, to the point of redundancy. However, these plot revelations and social commentaries are executed much more simply. It's all less fun, clever, and believable. It's just a lot less all around. The bad guys in Zootopia were already prejudice and implicit bias, but it's comparatively straightforward and in-your-face in the sequel. This is less realistic and true-to-life, and it also makes for a much less interesting movie. I just saw Zootopia 2 a couple of hours ago, and I'm struggling to remember elements of the film's basic plot. That's usually not a good sign for a movie's memorability or rewatchability, two things Zootopia had in spades.

I will give credit where it's due: there are some laugh-out-loud moments in Zootopia 2. It's not nearly as witty or consistently funny as its predecessor, but visual gags sometimes land, and there's a decent line about franchising successful movies. However, it immediately made me go, "Wait, but this is itself an unnecessary sequel. Should they say that here?" I've never heard of Fortune Feimster, who voices Nibbles Maplestick (hate this character's name, by the way), but she's hilarious. I won't say she gets the best lines in the movie, but her jokes land more often than the leads'. Whether this is how the character is written or just because she's in the film less often I leave to you to decide. However, a lot of the jokes in the movie had no effect on the audience I saw Zootopia 2 with. The theater was mostly children, so I don't even think it's a taste/maturity thing; this movie is just very hit-or-miss in the comedy department.

Another facet of Zootopia 2 that doesn't succeed with flying colors is its characters. I'm not surprised to report that the new characters aren't terribly interesting or memorable, but it's a shame to say the same for the leads. Nick and Judy were great in Zootopia and a big part of what made it so enjoyable, and here, they go through a very similar conflict, but it doesn't work nearly as well. As I mentioned earlier, part of this could be the familiarity. It feels disingenuous to see characters go through the motions of a previous arc again. This isn't unique to Zootopia 2, and in fact, I think sequels struggle with this quite often, especially when the first story had a definitive ending. There is no more growth baked into the characters, so what are you supposed to do? Mayor Winddancer is just silly. He doesn't seem like a real politician, like Bellwether and Lionheart did in the original, although I see what they were going for with him being an actor first. There's a good idea in there, and I love Patrick Warburton, but Winddancer lacks the depth of Kronk or any of the characters in the first Zootopia. I feel the same way about Nibbles, the Lynxley family, and even Gary De'Snake (Ke Huy Quan), who was a big part of the marketing. Some of these characters work better than others, but none are developed or funny enough to justify their presence. And worse yet, they take time from established characters like Chief Bogo and Clawhauser!

On that note, but regarding other characters from the first Zootopia, this movie has big Incredibles 2 energy. Zootopia 2 is desperate to shoehorn popular characters from the first movie in here by any means necessary. This character had a complete story? They add absolutely nothing to this movie? Too bad! I also think the cast of Zootopia 2 is too big for anyone to shine. There are too many side characters, too many villains, and too many voice actors. Did you know David Strathairn was in Zootopia 2? You probably won't because he barely talks despite being a major antagonist. What about Macaulay Culkin? Michelle Gomez? Seriously, what is with the stunt casting in this film? The closest thing I can think of in the first movie is Gazelle, but Shakira plays a fictional pop star who represents everything Zootopia stands for. That seems a lot less distracting and misplaced.

6/10

Zootopia 2 isn't the worst movie I've seen this year, and I don't care enough to be disappointed anymore. But it's also not very good, and offers very little that wasn't present and superior in the first Zootopia. I wouldn't really recommend this film unless you have Disney+ and plan to watch it there. Kids may get more out of this one, but they could always watch Bluey or something. There's just no good reason for Zootopia 2 to exist.